

I4C - MHA Advisory on Impersonation of Law Enforcement and Digital Arrest Scams

Publisher: I4C / MHA | **Topic:** gov_police_impersonation | **Date:** 2026-10-02
Official Source: <https://i4c.mha.gov.in/advisories/digital-arrest-police-impersonation.pdf>

Official Advisory: Ministry of Home Affairs & I4C: Public Advisory on 'Digital Arrest' Scams

Modus Operandi: Fake Police, CBI, Customs, and ED Officials

Fraudsters contact citizens via phone calls and WhatsApp/Skype video calls claiming to represent Delhi Police, CBI, NCB, Mumbai Customs, or ED. They allege that an illegal parcel containing narcotics, passports, or money-laundering debit cards sent via FedEx/DHL in the victim's name has been seized, or that an FIR has been registered against them.

Coercion, Fake Courtrooms, and 'Digital Arrest'

Fraudsters set up mock police stations or courtroom backdrops with fake uniforms, official seals, and forged arrest warrants. They order the victim to isolate themselves in a room and remain on continuous video call, declaring them under 'Digital Arrest'. Under threat of immediate physical arrest and public defamation, victims are coerced into transferring their lifetime savings into 'Government Secret Verification Accounts' or 'Reserve Escrow Accounts', promising return after verification.

Official Fact-Check and Legal Reality

1. 'Digital Arrest' DOES NOT EXIST under Indian criminal law (Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita / CrPC).
2. No police officer, court, or investigative agency (CBI, ED, NCB, Customs) conducts interrogations or issues arrest warrants over WhatsApp or Skype video.
3. Government agencies NEVER demand money transfers or security deposits to 'verify innocence' or clear criminal charges.
4. If you receive such a call, immediately disconnect, block the number, and do not panic.

Reporting Protocol

Immediately report digital arrest intimidation to the National Cybercrime Helpline 1930 and file a complaint on cybercrime.gov.in.

Citizen Action Checklist & Red Flags

- **Verify Sender Identity:** Always check official website addresses and header IDs (e.g., VM-SBI, AX-HDFC). Scammers use fake sender masks.
- **Never Share Authentication Secrets:** Passwords, OTPs, UPI PINs, and debit card CVVs are strictly confidential. Bank staff will NEVER ask for them.
- **Independent Verification:** If you receive a threat or alert about an account freeze, call the official bank branch number found on your physical card or bank statement.
- **Immediate Reporting:** Report cyber financial fraud within the Golden Hour by calling 1930 or visiting cybercrime.gov.in.

Frequently Asked Questions (Regulatory Clarifications)

Q1: Can money be deposited into my bank account by entering my UPI PIN?

A: No. A UPI PIN is solely an authorization to debit funds from your linked bank account. Receiving funds requires NO authentication or PIN entry.

Q2: What is the first action to take if money is fraudulently deducted?

A: Dial 1930 immediately to register the complaint on the Indian Cybercrime Coordination Centre (I4C) CFCFRMS portal so that the beneficiary account can be frozen before funds are withdrawn.

Q3: What should I do if an unknown caller threatens me with a police arrest over video call?

A: Disconnect immediately. Indian police and law enforcement agencies never issue summons, conduct investigations, or place citizens under 'Digital Arrest' via video calls.

Official Notice & Legal Status: This document is compiled for the ScamShield AI Knowledge Base from authentic public circulars, advisories, and directives issued by regulatory and enforcement authorities in India (including RBI, NPCI, I4C, MHA, SEBI, CERT-In, and DoT). All citizen rights, statutory duties, and liability ceilings are governed by relevant acts including the Information Technology Act 2000 and RBI Customer Protection Directives.